

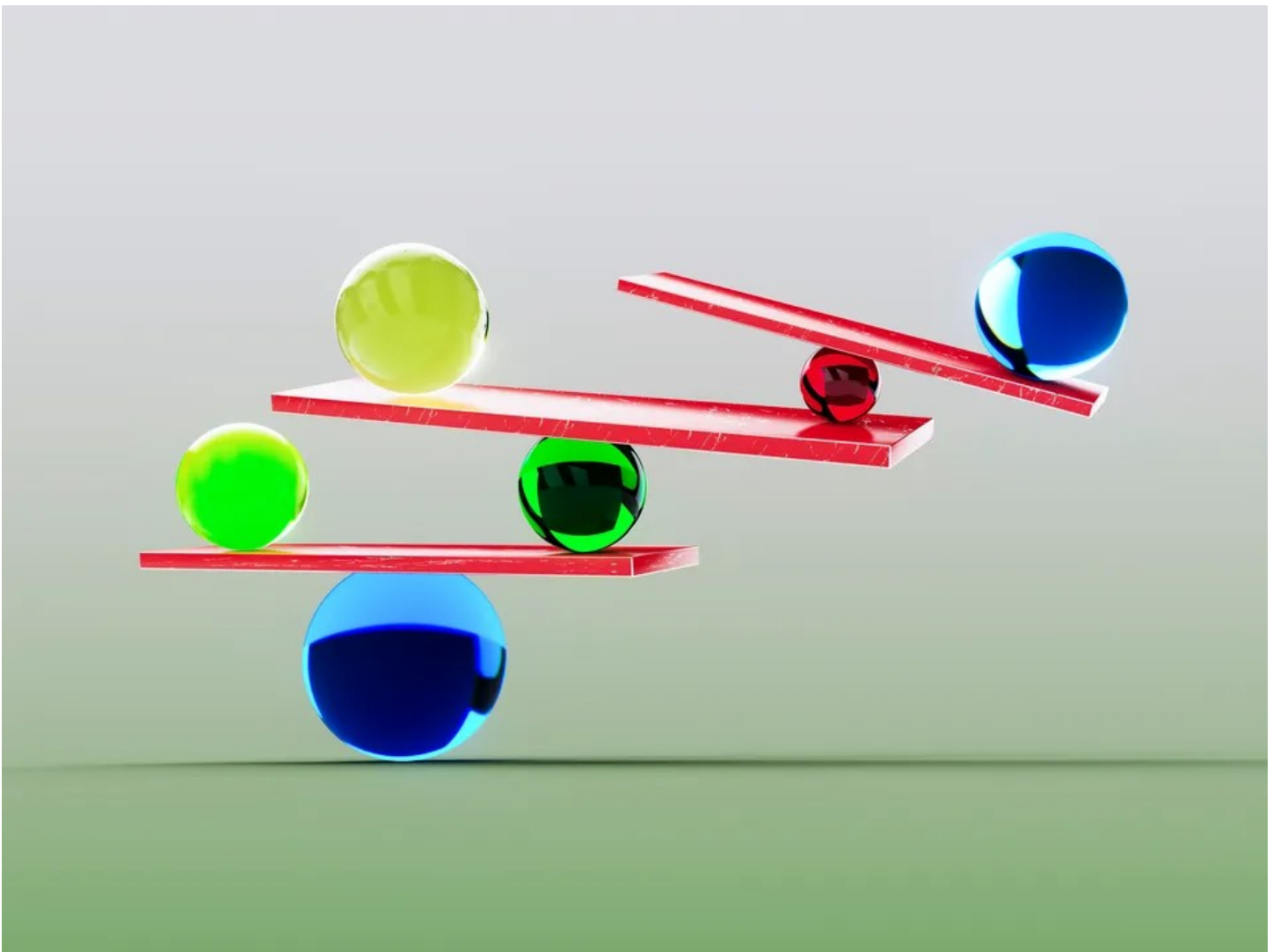
Life

The Method I Used to Reclaim 72 Hours a Week

Work should only take up 25% of our time. These three steps make that happen.

By [Amanda Goetz](#)

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There are 168 hours in a week. Even if you sleep eight hours a night (56 total) and work 40, you still have 72 hours left (72!) to be a friend, partner, parent, artist, athlete, neighbor, and overall well-rounded human. So why does it feel like your job eats up your whole life?

Allow me to introduce a concept I call “hustle without intention.” Most of us were raised to think that output equals worth. Productivity at work became the grown-up version of gold stars; we have to answer emails at 9:37 p.m. or someone “more serious” will surely take our spot. In taking the path of hustle without intention, we didn’t just get good at our jobs—we *became* our jobs. But pushing toward big career goals at the expense of joy, rest, and fun is the on-ramp to burnout—and the toxic side of hustle.

Ambition isn’t inherently bad. It’s when it takes over the entire plotline of the movie of your life that it turns toxic. If this sounds familiar, I promise there’s a way out. I am a two-time founder, five-time CMO, and mother of three who struggled to have it all—until I carved out space for all the parts of me I needed to fulfill. It’s easier said than done, but still, it’s doable. Here are three steps you can use to help you reclaim those 72 hours.

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1. Meet your characters

My solution is called Character Theory: a framework designed to acknowledge the

diverse cast inside of you and why “alignment” is so hard. Inside of each of us live characters with competing needs: the **CEO** (your ambition), the **Lover** (your need for intimacy), the **Friend** (a sense of belonging), the **Artist** (the spark of creativity), the **Caregiver/Doctor** (your need for self-care), the **Explorer** (your curiosity), and more. When you feel disconnected from yourself, it's usually because one or two characters hijack the script (hi, CEO) while the others never get any screen time.

Here's the reframe: Alignment actually comes from intentional imbalance. Life moves in seasons. Accept that you can choose which character leads *this month, this week, this day, or this moment*, and then rotate the camera.

2. Go on an ambition detox

Ambition is fuel. But like anything else, it needs to be moderated. The problem is when it turns into **toxic grit**, the flavor of ambition that blows past every red flag in the name of “just one more” launch, promo, or after-hours work session. In fact, I'd argue that's where joy and sustainable success go to die. Two traps fuel toxic grit in particular:

The Urgency Trap. Everything feels urgent because you're trying to be every character at once. A quick test is to stop and ask yourself: *If I don't do this today, what actually breaks?* Most of the time, nothing. Your nervous system just wants certainty, and some old programming may be scared of what will happen if you don't get it done immediately.

The Significance Trap. When everything is “important,” nothing is. You start optimizing volume (responding! updating! tweaking!) instead of value (shipping the thing that matters).

Layer on invisible labor, time zones, Slack in your pocket, and the dopamine drip of scrolling, and of course, the CEO keeps grabbing the mic. You're not broken. You're overloaded.

Here's your three-step detox plan (same ambition, less toxicity!):

- **Pick a two-do list.** Two needle-movers a day. Focus here first.

- **Add recovery on the calendar, not “when there’s time.”**
- **Name the season.** If you’re in a legit sprint, call it, set an end date, and pre-book the decompression and celebration time.

This is not about wanting less for your life. I’m simply asking you to contain the characters so it works for *all* of your life. Keeping one character’s energy from bleeding into another’s designated time ensures no one falls off script or grows toxic. When my CEO has a clear container (defined priorities, a shutdown ritual), she does her job *better*.

3. Reclaim your five-to-nine—for all of your characters

When I was a working mom with three kids under the age of four, no one batted an eye when I left the office at 5 p.m. to relieve the nanny and be with my children. Yet we feel guilty for doing the same for a workout class, rest, or even prioritizing a date.

We obsess over the nine-to-five and ignore the **five-to nine**: the before-and-after-work hours that turn into scroll-and-collapse if you don’t give them a job. It’s important to bring back the non-CEO cast *on purpose*.

Before I share my five-to nine, I want to caution against another toxic extreme: when we try to over-maximize self-care, which is honestly just matcha-flavored toxic grit. This might sound familiar from what you see on social media: influencers waking up at ungodly hours to cram as much as possible into every waking moment. Even in this, we push past the needs of our other characters (like the socialite, lover, or explorer) to try and get the gold star for self-care. Remember: Claiming your five-to nine is about acknowledging the diverse cast and trying to move multiple plotlines forward.

To feel alignment with your “characters,” make a one-page “cast schedule” for weeknights. Here’s an example:

- **Monday — Athlete:** 30 minutes to move your body (walking counts).
- **Tuesday — Friend/Socialite:** One real conversation or plan something you look forward to.
- **Wednesday — Artist/Creative:** Make something that isn’t monetized. Yes, even if

it's not pretty.

- **Thursday — Lover/Partner:** Devices down, actual connection.
- **Friday — Play/Explorer:** Try a mini adventure—new class, new neighborhood, new recipe.

In order to stick to your five-to nine plans, you need to honor the transition. Create a ritual that signals to your body that work is ending and a new character is stepping into the spotlight. Feel free to steal mine: I create my two-do list for the next day, exit out of tabs I don't need, and lastly, say it out loud: "Workday closed, artist open." Then do something sensory that will allow the next character to enter the spotlight: shower, stretch, take a short walk, or play music you only listen to after work.

The bottom line

A movie with only one character isn't much fun to watch. If you give 100% (of focus, attention, and effort) to the 25% of your time that you designate to your CEO, that's enough. When you rotate the camera on purpose and stop letting urgency and fake significance run the show, you will make space for the characters that bring you back to yourself.

The wild part? Your results usually get better. Fewer gold stars, more good work. Fewer tabs, more life. That's the kind of "imbalance" I can get behind.



[Amanda Goetz](#) is a 2× founder, 4× chief marketing officer, and was a single mom to three small children before finding love again. In her new book, *[Toxic Grit: How to Have It All and \(Actually\) Love What You Have](#)*, Goetz shares what it took to climb the corporate ladder, build ... [Read More](#)

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